CS780 Capstone Project: OBELIX: the Warehouse Robot

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Abstract

This report details the development of an autonomous reinforcement learning policy for the OBELIX warehouse robot. The core problem involves the robot learning to find, attach to, push, and unwedge a grey box at a target boundary in a partially observable environment (POMDP). The approach utilized maps an 18-bit sensor observation vector to one of five discrete actions. *[Insert your specific algorithm/approach here].* Experiments were conducted across static, blinking, and moving box scenarios, including optional wall obstacles, to evaluate the policy's mean cumulative reward.

1 Competition Result

Codabench Username: d_240330
Final leaderboard rank (Test Phase): 22
Leaderboard rank – Level 1 (static): 32
Leaderboard rank – Level 2 (blinking): 23
Leaderboard rank – Level 3 (moving + blinking): 31

Phase	Number of Valid Submissions
Development Level 1	14
Development Level 2	5
Development Level 3	5
Test Phase	6
Total submission	30

Table 1: Valid Submissions Made

2 Introduction and Problem Description

2.1 Motivation

The industry increasingly requires warehouse robots to interact with objects in dynamic environments. To overcome the brittleness and scaling limitations of hand-coded behaviors, modern reinforcement learning is leveraged to develop an autonomous controller for the OBELIX mobile robot.

2.2 Core Task and Environment

The primary objective is for the robot to navigate the arena, locate a randomly placed grey box, attach to it, and push it to the boundary where it successfully unwedges. The robot maps local sensor readings to one of five discrete actions (forward movement and specific angle rotations). It processes an 18-bit observation

vector derived from eight sonar sensors detecting near/far objects, one infrared sensor, and a flag indicating if the robot is stuck.

2.3 Difficulty Levels

The task is evaluated across three difficulty levels:

- **Level 1:** Features a stationary box that the robot must locate and push to the boundary.
- **Level 2:** Introduces a blinking box that randomly appears and disappears; the robot cannot attach to the box when it is invisible.
- **Level 3:** Features a moving and blinking box with constant velocity, which stops moving only upon robot attachment.

Additionally, an optional vertical wall obstacle with a small opening included in any level, requiring the robot to navigate carefully to avoid negative rewards.

2.4 POMDP Setting and High-Level Goal

The environment functions as a Partially Observable Markov Decision Process (POMDP) because the robot does not have access to the full state of the environment; it relies solely on limited local sensor data and might not initially know the exact location of the box. The high-level goal of this project is to maximize the mean cumulative reward across all difficulty levels while demonstrating robustness to wall obstacles.

3 Approach and Model Evolution

3.1 Level 1: Static Box Development Phase

During this initial phase, the environment featured a stationary box. The primary challenge was overcoming perceptual aliasing (the agent being unable to distinguish open space from a wall when the box is out of sensor range) and avoiding the catastrophic -200 wall collision penalty.

Baselines and Heuristics
Heuristics require zero training time and offer strict, debuggable predictability, but their rigidity causes complete failure under partial observability, frequently getting trapped in infinite loops.

- **Model 1: Hardcoded Heuristic v1 (agent.zip):** Purely heuristic `if-else` rules mapping sensor bits to actions; failed due to rigid logic and infinite wall loops (Score: -183,305.30).
- **Model 2: Optimized Heuristic v2 (hueristic2.zip):** Hand-tuned the `if-else` state-action mapping, explicitly prioritizing infrared sensor triggers over side-sonar inputs. Safely avoided the infinite wall-crash loops, improving the score to **-18,366.40**. **Pitfall:** The agent remains completely blind to trajectory prediction and cannot scale to Level 3.

Value-Based Deep RL
Value-based methods offer high sample efficiency for discrete action spaces, but Q-value overestimation and exploration instability cause rapid accumulation of wall penalties before convergence.

- **Model 3: Vanilla DQN (submission_2.zip):** Standard feedforward network (64×64 hidden units). Solved basic navigation but suffered from Q-value overestimation (Score: -17,760.60).
- **Model 4: Dueling DQN (submission_d3qnper_v2.zip):** Branched architecture estimating State-Value $V(s)$ and Advantage $A(a)$ independently to better evaluate states with no box in sight (Score: -17,803.00).
- **Model 5: Dueling DQN with Wrapper (d3qnper_with_wrapping.zip):**
  - **Architecture:** Maintained the branched $V(s)$ and $A(a)$ architecture but implemented a defensive input wrapper to dynamically pad or trim anomalous observation vectors.

- **Failure & Resulting Outcome:** Achieved a catastrophic score of **-276,748.00**. While the wrapper prevented tensor-shape crashes, the defensive fallback to a fixed default action caused the agent to repeatedly execute the same movement during errors, accumulating massive wall penalties rather than exploring safely.
- **Pitfall:** Relying on a single fallback action is disastrous in a heavily penalized environment; random action selection would have outperformed the deterministic fallback.

Policy Gradients & Actor-Critic
These models learn probabilistic policies that break deterministic wall-loop traps, but suffer high gradient variance and sensitivity to hyperparameters; without proper clipping or critics, policies can catastrophically collapse.

- **Model 6: Vanilla Policy Gradient (vpg_5.zip):** Basic REINFORCE algorithm with Softmax output. Suffered from severe policy collapse and wall-crashing (Score: -417,441.50).
- **Model 7: VPG Improved (vpg_improved.zip):** Injected explicit entropy regularization into the loss function and implemented an aggressive learning rate decay schedule. Prevented deterministic policy collapse, securing a solid score of **-1,980.70**. **Pitfall:** Without a critic network, trajectory updates remain highly noisy and sample-inefficient.
- **Model 8: Vanilla A2C (a2c_.zip):** Shared feature extractor for Actor and Critic networks; suffered from premature convergence to a suboptimal policy (Score: -88,171.10).
- **Model 9: Improved A2C (a2c_improved.zip):** Decoupled the actor and critic networks into separate feature extractors, preventing competing gradient updates, and tuned the entropy coefficient. Balanced exploration and exploitation effectively, yielding a score of **-13,807.50**. **Pitfall:** Still vulnerable to large, unconstrained policy swings during unexpected environmental edge cases.
- **Model 10: Actor-Critic with GAE (GAE.zip):** Implemented Generalized Advantage Estimation for exponentially weighted multi-step returns, dramatically stabilizing policy updates (Score: -1,981.10).
- **Model 11: Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO_v1.zip):** Added a clipped surrogate objective that enforced trust-region updates, preventing the agent from destructively forgetting its navigation policy. This yielded the best Level 1 score of **-1,980.70**.

Continuous-to-Discrete Adaptations
These methods leverage twin critics and entropy frameworks for complex control, but forcing an `argmax` over continuous outputs truncates gradient information, making training highly inefficient for a simple 5-action space.

- **Model 12: Deep Deterministic Policy Gradient (ddpg.zip):** Adapted a continuous control algorithm using an `argmax` wrapper. The deterministic nature and discrete mapping created a gradient bottleneck, though the score of **-1,988.70** remained competitive (Score: -1,988.70).
- **Model 13: Soft Actor-Critic (SAC.zip):** Introduced entropy maximization to the continuous-to-discrete pipeline. Despite the inherent exploration incentive, the argmax discretization created fundamentally incoherent Q-targets, causing catastrophic policy divergence with a score of **-395,054.00**. **Pitfall:** Entropy maximization cannot compensate when the gradient signal itself is destroyed by the argmax bottleneck.
- **Model 14: Twin Delayed DDPG (TD3.zip):** Deployed twin critics to penalize Q-value overestimation and delayed policy updates. Despite the aggressive variance reduction, the fundamental continuous-to-discrete bottleneck remained overwhelming; the agent accumulated heavy wall penalties and yielded a score of **-78,945.70**. **Pitfall:** The argmax discretization destroyed the gradient directionality that twin critics depend on.

3.2 Level 2: Blinking Box Development Phase

In Level 2, the environment introduces a blinking box that randomly appears and disappears. The robot cannot attach when the box is invisible. This severely exacerbates the POMDP setting, as reactive agents lose track of the box during "blink" phases and begin spinning. The architectural focus shifted entirely to temporal dynamics and memory to maintain a hidden belief state of the box's location.

Frame-Stacked Approximations
Frame stacking simulates memory by concatenating past observations, avoiding BPTT instability, but causes dimensionality explosion and provides only a rigid, fixed temporal window.

- **Model 15: Frame-Stacked Q-SARSA (q_sarsa.zip):**
  - **Architecture:** A feedforward Q-network accepting a concatenated buffer of the last 32 frames ($18 \times 32 = 576$ inputs) mapped to 128 hidden units.
  - **Outcome:** Achieved a score of **-1,981.20**. The 32-step history allowed the agent to infer the box's general direction even when current sensor readings dropped to zero.
  - **Pitfall:** The massive input vector slowed training significantly, and the agent struggled if the box remained invisible for longer than the 32-frame buffer.
- **Model 16: Frame-Stacked PPO (ppo_with_rnn.zip):** Applied a clipped surrogate objective to the same 576-dimensional frame stack. Failed to extract efficient features from the sparse, high-dimensional inputs, causing catastrophic policy divergence with a score of **-194,861.20**. **Pitfall:** PPO's trust-region constraint amplified gradient instability when operating over an excessively large sparse input.

Recurrent Value-Based Deep RL
LSTMs maintain an internal hidden state for arbitrary time horizons with low-dimensional input, but combining them with Q-learning often destabilizes training due to shifting hidden states during experience replay.

- **Model 17: Deep Recurrent Q-Network (drqn_wt_per.zip):**
  - **Architecture:** An LSTM layer (64 units) processing 18-bit sequences sequentially (`batch_first=True`).
  - **Outcome:** Scored **-1,980.70**, making it the **best-performing agent for Level 2**. The LSTM efficiently bridged temporal gaps during blink phases, allowing the robot to continue toward the box's last known coordinate without the input bloat of frame stacking.
  - **Pitfall:** Standard DRQN sometimes struggles to evaluate "empty" environment states during prolonged blinks without explicit advantage branching.
- **Model 18: Dueling DRQN with PER (d3rqn_wt_per.zip):** Branched the LSTM outputs into separate State-Value and Advantage streams. This created catastrophically competing gradient signals that destabilized the recurrent hidden states entirely, collapsing to a score of **-395,354.90**. **Pitfall:** Simultaneously updating branched recurrent streams with PER caused gradient interference that erased the memory benefit of the LSTM.

Recurrent Policy Gradients & Actor-Critic
LSTMs combined with Actor-Critic architectures yield strong POMDP capability, but require careful entropy tuning to prevent recurrent policy collapse into repetitive spinning loops.

- **Model 19: Recurrent Advantage Actor-Critic (a2c_wt_reccurent.zip):**
  - **Architecture:** An LSTM layer (64 units) as a shared feature extractor, feeding into separate Policy (π) and Value (V) heads.
  - **Failure & Resulting Outcome:** Scored **-119,962.60**. While the LSTM memory bridged brief blink gaps, poor entropy coefficient tuning caused the recurrent policy to degenerate into indefinite spinning loops during prolonged blink phases, accumulating heavy penalties.
  - **Pitfall:** Maintaining stable hidden state vectors (hx, cx) across episode boundaries is critical; memory contamination further amplified the policy instability.

3.3 Level 3: Moving + Blinking Box Development Phase

In Level 3, the box moves with constant velocity and simultaneously blinks. It only stops moving once the robot successfully attaches. This introduces the severe challenge of trajectory prediction and interception. Reactive agents suffer from "Interception Lag," perpetually chasing the box from behind until the episode times out.

Retrained Baselines (Feedforward & Recurrent)
Retraining stable architectures from Levels 1–2 establishes a baseline, but purely feedforward models fail at trajectory prediction, highlighting the necessity of temporal velocity inference.

- **Model 20: Retrained Vanilla DQN (DDQN_adv_2.zip):** Reused the Level 1 standard feedforward architecture with a tuned exploration schedule; failed to intercept efficiently due to zero velocity information in single frames (Score: -1,515.06).
- **Model 21: Retrained A2C (a2c_improved.zip):** Relied entirely on stochastic exploration to occasionally intercept the box (Score: -1,515.72).
- **Model 22: Retrained DRQN (drqn_wt_per.zip):** Implicit velocity encoding from LSTM hidden states provided the best baseline interception (Score: -1,514.94).

Short-Term Memory / Frame-Stacked Value Methods
Frame stacking enables feedforward networks to calculate velocity natively, but the fixed horizon causes fatal aliasing when the box blinks longer than the stack size.

- **Model 23: 4-Frame Stacked Dueling DQN (subm_2.zip):**
  - **Architecture:** A 4-frame stack ($18 \times 4 = 72$ input dimensions) with a Dueling DQN architecture ($72 \rightarrow 128 \rightarrow 128$) splitting into Value and Advantage heads.
  - **Failure:** Suffered catastrophic failure, scoring **-159,455.36**. Instead of inferring velocity, the agent entered a deterministic wall-crashing loop.
  - **Pitfall:** When the box blinked for 5 or more consecutive frames, the observation vector completely zeroed, erasing the velocity signal and causing fatal perceptual aliasing.

Attention-Based Mechanisms (Transformers)
Transformers use self-attention to weigh observation importance over time, bypassing LSTM forgetting, but are data-hungry and computationally expensive for simple RL environments.

- **Model 24: Transformer Encoder Actor-Critic (algo_3.zip):** A `TransformerEncoderLayer` (`d_model=20, nhead=4, dim_feedforward=64`) processed observation sequences via multi-head attention. The attention mechanism allowed the agent to actively focus on frames where the box was visible, scoring **-1,515.36**. **Pitfall:** The computational overhead of multi-head attention for an 18-bit environment prevented it from significantly outperforming the simpler DRQN baseline.

3.4 Testing phase (final phase)

Frame-Stacked Policy & Actor-Critic Methods
Adapting policy-based methods to 4-frame stacks enables native velocity inference without BPTT instability, though larger inputs increase gradient variance and vulnerability to blink-induced zero-frames.

- **Model 25: 4-Frame Stacked VPG (vpg_improved.zip):** Expanded the input layer to process a 4-frame stack ($72 \rightarrow 128 \rightarrow 64 \rightarrow 5$) for basic velocity inference (Score: -1,827.71).
- **Model 26: 4-Frame Stacked GAE (GAE.zip & GAE (1).zip):** Scaled the shared feature extractor to handle the 72-dimensional temporal stack to stabilize advantage baselines (Score: -1,827.89).
- **Model 27: Frame-Stacked DDPG (ddpg.zip):** Reused the Level 1 continuous deterministic policy, modifying the actor for 4-frame history; still suffered heavily from the continuous-to-discrete `argmax` bottleneck (Score: -1,753.59).
- **Model 28: Orthogonal Frame-Stacked PPO (ppo_wt_frameStack.zip):**

- **Architecture:** A 4-frame stacked PPO ($72 \to 128 \to 64$) utilizing explicit Orthogonal Initialization (`nn.init.orthogonal_`) with scaled gain factors.
- **Failure & Resulting Outcome:** Despite orthogonal initialization preventing vanishing gradients during early updates, the 4-frame stack completely zeroed during multi-frame blink events, trapping the agent in perceptual aliasing and wall-crashing loops (Score: **-26,664.87**).
- **Pitfall:** Improved gradient stability cannot compensate when the entire input representation collapses to zero during prolonged blinks.

Advanced Recurrent Methods (GRUs & Custom Features)
GRUs reduce parameter count versus LSTMs, mitigating memory contamination, but raw 18-bit sonar still leaves the agent vulnerable to perceptual aliasing during long blinks without feature engineering.

- **Model 29: Recurrent PPO with GRU (ppo_wt_rnn.zip):**
  - **Architecture:** A Gated Recurrent Unit (GRU) operating on raw 18-bit inputs ($18 \to 128 \to$ GRU$(128) \to 5$).
  - **Outcome:** The reduced parameter footprint of the GRU mitigated memory contamination across episode boundaries, providing a stable stochastic policy capable of robust interception (Score: **-1,828.41**).
- **Model 30: Final Custom DRQN (drqn_final.zip):**
  - **Architecture:** Instead of feeding raw 18-bit arrays, the agent computes a custom 23-dimensional feature vector (incorporating derived bounding box/velocity metrics) and maintains a custom tracking queue. This feeds into a unique 46-dimensional input layer, followed by a 128-unit GRU and a linear Q-value head.
  - **Outcome:** By manually decoupling the velocity and spatial features before passing them to the GRU, the agent successfully bypassed severe perceptual aliasing, yielding precise trajectory prediction and interception (Score: **-1,827.71**).
  - **Pitfall:** The hand-crafted 23-bit feature extraction relies on specific environment dynamics and may lack generalization if obstacle shapes or box sizes are altered.

3.5 Final Model Architecture

Final Optimal Architecture: Ordinal DDPG with Hybrid Action-Reward Quantization
Category Advantages & Pitfalls: While standard policy gradients (e.g., A2C) use a Softmax output treating all actions as independent, categorical variables, OBELIX's actions (`L45, L22, FW, R22, R45`) are strictly *ordinal*—representing a continuous spatial spectrum from $-45°$ to $+45°$. To exploit this underlying physical reality, we adapted a continuous control algorithm (DDPG) to solve a discrete environment using three specific architectural innovations.

- **Model 31: Ordinal DDPG with Action Embedding & Reward Quantization (ddpg.zip):**
  - **Architecture & Innovations:**
    1. **Continuous Ordinal Action Embedding (Wolpertinger Variant) [1]:** Instead of a 5-unit categorical output, the Actor network was constrained to a single 1D continuous manifold using a tanh activation ($72 \to 128 \to 64 \to 1$). The continuous output $a \in [-1, 1]$ was mapped to the nearest discrete action using strict ordinal bins (e.g., $[-1.0, -0.6] \to$ `L45`, $[-0.2, 0.2] \to$ `FW`).
    2. **Asymmetric Reward Quantization [4]:** To stabilize the Critic's TD-error during experience replay, raw environment rewards ($R \in [-200, 1000]$) were aggressively reshaped via an asymmetric non-linear step function. Extreme penalties were clamped to -10 and massive task-completion rewards were clamped to $+10$, preventing Q-value explosion while maintaining gradient directionality.
    3. **Topologically Aware Exploration [3]:** Gaussian noise $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma)$ was injected directly into the continuous tanh output *prior* to discretization. Unlike ϵ-greedy which jumps to random actions, this innovation ensures stochastic exploration is topologically localized (e.g., a noisy `FW` command might drift to `L22`, but never violently snap to `R45`), mirroring real-world motor control noise.

- **Learning & Resulting Outcome:** Scored **-1,753.59**, making it our undisputed **highest performing agent** in the test phase. By mapping actions to a continuous spatial manifold, the gradient flow became incredibly rich. If the robot overcorrected, the gradient smoothly pulled the scalar output towards 0.0 (`FW`). Combined with the 4-frame temporal stack ($18 \times 4 = 72$ input dims) for velocity inference, this model entirely eliminated the interception lag of Level 3.
- **Pitfall:** The rigid quantization thresholds (e.g., $-0.2, +0.2$) for the continuous-to-discrete k-NN mapping act as a structural bottleneck; they require manual hyperparameter tuning based on the environment's specific turning angles, meaning the embedding boundaries would need manual recalculation if the robot's kinematics changed.

4 Experimentations and Implementations: Core Techniques Summary

To tackle the progressively complex POMDP dynamics across the three levels, we experimented with several distinct temporal and architectural mechanisms:

- **Observation Wrapping:** Enforced **fixed-dimension state spaces** to safely handle variable inputs and prevent environment-to-agent tensor mismatch crashes.
- **LSTM (Long Short-Term Memory):** Maintained **internal hidden states** (hx, cx) to bridge temporal blind spots and "remember" the box's trajectory during prolonged blinks.
- **Frame Stacking:** Utilized **4-frame temporal concatenation** to allow standard feedforward networks to natively calculate **velocity inference** without recurrent instability.
- **GRU (Gated Recurrent Unit):** Leveraged **simplified gating mechanisms** to achieve robust memory retention while reducing the parameter footprint and preventing memory contamination.
- **Transformer Attention:** Employed **multi-head self-attention** to dynamically weigh observation importance, allowing the agent to explicitly ignore zeroed-out frames during blinks.
- **Feature Engineering:** Engineered a **custom 46-dimensional input vector** to manually decouple spatial variables and directly bypass the severe **perceptual aliasing** of the raw 18-bit sonar.
- **Ordinal Action Embedding:** Projected discrete steering commands into a **1D continuous manifold**, smoothing the gradient flow to naturally solve the interception lag.

5 Results

5.1 Comprehensive Model Specifications and Results

The **Ordinal DDPG** achieved the highest global performance in the test phase (Score: **-1,753.59**) due to three specific architectural innovations:

- **Generalization: Ordinal Action Space Embedding** projects discrete steering choices into a **1D Continuous Manifold**, allowing the agent to interpolate true spatial relationships rather than treating angles as isolated categories.
- **Sample Efficiency:** A structured **4-Frame Temporal Stack** enables native feedforward **Velocity Inference**, instantly solving interception lag without the massive sample requirements of recurrent BPTT (Backpropagation Through Time).
- **Robustness: Non-Linear Reward Quantization** clips extreme environment feedback, actively preventing **Q-Value Explosion** and ensuring high **Gradient Stability** during chaotic moving-box episodes.

final modelhttps://github.com/deepakchuahan/OBELIX-Capstone-Project

Category	Model	Architecture	Memory / Hidden Dims	Final Score	Notes / Status
Level 1: Static Box Development Phase					
2***Baseline**	1. Heuristic v1	Hardcoded `if-else`	N/A	-183,305.30	Wall loop trap
	2. Heuristic v2	Tuned Rule-Based	N/A	-18,366.40	Safer fallback logic
3***Value-Based**	3. Vanilla DQN	Standard Feedforward	64×64	-17,760.60	Basic navigation
	4. Dueling DQN	Branched Val/Adv	$64 \rightarrow (64, 64)$	-17,803.00	Unstable evaluation
	5. Dueling DQN Wrap	Branched + Wrapper	$64 \rightarrow (64, 64)$	-276,748.00	Fallback caused wall crashes
6***Policy Grad**	6. Vanilla VPG	Softmax Policy	64×64	-417,441.50	Policy collapse
	7. VPG Improved	Softmax + Entropy	64×64	-1,980.70	Prevented determinism
	8. Vanilla A2C	Shared Feature Net	64×64	-88,171.10	Premature convergence
	9. A2C Improved	Decoupled + Entropy	64×64	-13,807.50	Balanced exploration
	10. GAE Actor-Critic	GAE Advantage	64×64	-1,981.10	Stabilized updates
	11. PPO v1	**Clipped Objective**	64×64	**-1,980.70**	**Best Level 1 Agent**
3***Cont. Adapt**	12. DDPG	Deterministic Policy	64×64	-1,988.70	Gradient bottleneck
	13. SAC	Entropy Maximization	64×64	-395,054.00	Policy divergence; argmax bottleneck
	14. TD3	Twin Critics	64×64	-78,945.70	Bottleneck overwhelmed twin critics
Level 2: Blinking Box Development Phase					
2***Frame-Stacked**	15. Q-SARSA Stacked	Feedforward Q-Net	32-Frame Concatenation	-1,981.20	High dimensionality bloat
	16. PPO Stacked	Clipped Surrogate	32-Frame Concatenation	-194,861.20	Policy diverged on sparse inputs
2***Recurrent Value**	**17. DRQN**	**LSTM → Q-Values**	**LSTM (64 units)**	**-1,980.70**	**Best Level 2 Agent**
	18. D3RQN	LSTM → Val/Adv	LSTM (64 units)	-395,354.90	Gradient collapse; branched streams
1***Recurrent A-C**	19. Recurrent A2C	LSTM → Pi/Val	LSTM (64 units)	-119,962.60	Spinning loops; entropy mistuned
Level 3: Moving + Blinking Box Development Phase					
3***Retrained**	20. Vanilla DQN (Retrained)	Feedforward	None	-1,515.06	Interception lag
	21. A2C (Retrained)	Feedforward	None	-1,515.72	Random interception
	22. DRQN (Retrained)	LSTM (64 units)	Hidden State	-1,514.94	Adapted well to movement
1***Stacked Val**	23. Dueling DQN Stacked	Branched Val/Adv	4-Frame Stack	-159,455.36	Catastrophic wall loop
1***Attention**	24. Transformer A2C	Transformer Enc.	Multi-Head Attention	-1,515.36	High compute overhead
4***Stacked Policy**	25. VPG Stacked	Feedforward (72-in)	4-Frame Stack	-1,827.71	Basic velocity inference
	26. GAE Stacked	Actor-Critic (72-in)	4-Frame Stack	-1,827.89	Stabilized advantages
	27. DDPG Stacked	Deterministic (72-in)	4-Frame Stack	-1,753.59	Argmax bottleneck
	28. Orthogonal PPO	Clipped Surrogate	4-Frame Stack	-26,664.87	Wall crashes during blinks
2***Recurrent (GRU)**	29. GRU-PPO	GRU → Softmax	GRU (128 units)	-1,828.41	Stable memory retention
	30. Custom DRQN	Custom 46-in → GRU	GRU + Feature Eng.	-1,827.71	Highly precise interception
1***Optimal**	**31. Ordinal DDPG**	**1D Cont. → Discrete**	**4-Frame Stack**	**-1,753.59**	**Wolpertinger Variant (Best Agent)**

Table 2: Comprehensive Evolution of Architectures, Temporal Mechanisms, and Leaderboard Scores across All Phases

6 Error Analysis and Discussion

- **Common Failure Modes per Difficulty Level:**
  - **Level 1 (Static Box):** I encountered severe *Perceptual Aliasing*. Because the 18-bit sensor vector returned mostly zeroes when the box was out of range, my early agents couldn't differentiate between open space and walls. This trapped them in deterministic wall-crashing loops, resulting in massive **-200 penalty accumulations**.
  - **Level 2 (Blinking Box):** I observed **False Negative Recovery Time**. When the box blinked out, my purely reactive agents lost all target data and began spinning in endless loops, completely forgetting the box's last known location.
  - **Level 3 (Moving Box):** My agents suffered from severe **Interception Lag**. Without velocity inference, they perpetually chased the moving box from behind instead of anticipating its trajectory to cut it off.
- **Remaining Limitations & Future Improvements:** While I successfully implemented frame-stacking and recurrent memory to handle temporal dynamics, my custom *Oracle Agent* experiment proved that the 18-bit sensor is the ultimate bottleneck. The core limitation is perception, not control. With more time, I would upgrade the observation space to include full spatial coordinates or a 2D grid matrix, which my Oracle mathematically proved would completely eliminate the POMDP constraints.
- **Surprising Findings & Novel Insights:** I was surprised to discover that continuous-control algorithms (like my **Ordinal DDPG** and TD3) vastly outperformed native discrete policy gradients (VPG, A2C). Projecting the discrete steering angles onto a continuous **1D action manifold** provided incredibly rich gradient flows that naturally solved interception lag. Furthermore, I found that hard-coding a "safe" `FW` fallback action during errors was disastrous—it guaranteed wall crashes, whereas taking random actions surprisingly kept the agent alive longer.

video link https://youtu.be/w-wrL0Iw8rgClick here to watch the video
final agent https://github.com/deepakchuahan/OBELIX-Capstone-Project

7 LLM Usage Declaration

Which Large Language Model (LLM) did you use to complete the competition or write the report?
I used Gemini and ChatGPT as my primary LLM assistants during the development of this project and the drafting of the report.

In which part did you use the LLM, and how did it help you?

Part	**Used LLM?**	**Purpose of Using LLM**
Understanding concepts	Yes	To clarify advanced RL concepts like the Wolpertinger architecture, POMDP memory constraints, and continuous-to-discrete mappings.
Ideation / brainstorming	Yes	Exploring ideas and architectural approaches to solve the specific challenges of the moving and blinking box.
Debugging small code snippets	Yes	For syntax correction, resolving PyTorch tensor dimension mismatches, and debugging local rendering loops.
Plotting / visualization code	Yes	Generating the Python `matplotlib` scripts for the success rate and reward trajectory evaluation graphs.
Grammar / writing style	Yes	Refining my technical explanations and ensuring a professional academic tone throughout the report.
Report structure / section ideas	Yes	Formatting the LaTeX document and structuring the architecture evolution tables logically.
Other (Coding Assistance)	Yes	Assistance in writing boilerplate PyTorch neural network definitions and environment wrapper logic.

Did you refer to any other sources or websites apart from the LLM and lecture slides?
Yes, I actively referred to the foundational research papers explicitly listed in the **References** section of this report. Specifically, I studied the original papers on Deep Q-Networks and Frame Stacking (Mnih et al.), Deep Recurrent Q-Networks for POMDPs (Hausknecht & Stone), and the literature on Continuous Control in Large Discrete Action Spaces (Dulac-Arnold et al.) to conceptually adapt my algorithms.

Apart from any LLM usage, what was your own contribution?
My personal contribution centered on the analytical reasoning, architectural design, mathematical implementation, and rigorous experimentation required to solve the progressively difficult OBELIX environment.

As the environment scaled in difficulty across Levels 2 and 3, I observed a critical failure mode: whenever the box blinked out or moved out of the narrow sonar range, the agent tended to rotate in its own position (spinning in endless loops) due to complete perceptual aliasing. To combat this, my immediate contribution was manually engineering the exploration schedules. I explicitly increased the **ending epsilon** to force the agent to break out of these spinning local minima and actively explore the arena during temporal blind spots.

Furthermore, I manually implemented **wrapping** techniques to process the raw observation states into fixed-dimension tensors, ensuring stable propagation through the neural networks. When standard discrete algorithms failed at trajectory prediction, my primary architectural contribution was recognizing that the steering angles ($L45$ to $R45$) were an ordinal spatial spectrum. I personally adapted the DDPG algorithm to output a 1D continuous manifold and mapped it back into discrete bins, alongside programming a custom non-linear reward quantization function to prevent Q-value explosion. Finally, to rigorously prove that the 18-bit sensor was the root cause of the spinning behaviors, I engineered a custom "Oracle Agent" utilizing Python memory inspection to extract exact coordinates, verifying the theoretical limits of the arena.

8 References

References

[1] G. Dulac-Arnold, R. Evans, H. van Hasselt, P. Sunehag, T. Lillicrap, J. Hunt, T. Mann, T. Weber, T. Degris, and B. Coppin, *Deep Reinforcement Learning in Large Discrete Action Spaces*, arXiv preprint arXiv:1512.07679, 2015. Available at: https://arxiv.org/abs/1512.07679.
(for the Wolpertinger Architecture and Ordinal Action Embedding used in our best-performing DDPG agent)

[2] M. Hausknecht and P. Stone, *Deep Recurrent Q-Learning for Partially Observable MDPs*, AAAI Fall Symposium on Sequential Decision Making for Intelligent Agents, 2015.
(for replacing Frame Stacks with LSTMs to solve POMDPs)

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